



“Digital convergence obscures physical and temporal boundaries...”

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ings still prevail, making the idea of convergence both slippery and richer. This is a good thing, because dictionary definitions can sometimes be straitjackets, and digital onvergence is different things to different people.

These different meanings of the term play out in different ways when we speak of digital convergence. There are shades of the biological idea of convergence, where different media and technologies develop similar features (your cell phone includes a camera while your camera may double up as an MP3 player). The mathematical idea of convergence, in the sense of a series of events adding up to a finite, manageable whole, highlights the manner in which this current talk of digital convergence is just the current consequence of media and knowledge coming together, which began thousands of years ago when people scribbled on cave walls. And of course, while the physiological definition reminds us that despite the wonders of technology, we need to focus our eyes inward, to reflect and think about the meanings and consequences of technological marvels.

However, the focus of this piece is not on biological, mathematical or physiological convergence. It is on digital convergence, and what it means for us as learners and educators. In this context, I would like to speak about three different kinds of convergence. The first is *digital convergence*, the kind of convergence that has received a great deal of attention lately (this special issue is a good example). This digital convergence is, for the most part, here already, which is maybe why we spend so much time talking about it.

Digital Convergence

The words *digital* and *convergence* taken independently or together are today's latest buzzwords. People have argued that this new world of ubiqui-

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Look up the word ‘convergence’ in the dictionary, and you will come across a range of meanings. My favourite is the reasonably useless definition that says convergence is “the act, condition, quality, or fact of converging.”

Huh? Other meanings and uses of the word are not quite as circular. For instance, in biology, convergent evolution means the adaptive evolution of superficially similar structures, such as wings in birds and insects. In mathematics, convergence is the property of approaching a limit, or as my friend Hartosh said, convergence is the way in which infinities can be controlled, captured and understood. In physiology—and this was something I didn’t know—it is the coordinated turning of the eyes inward to focus on an object at close range (what in other words we would call being cross-eyed). And finally, convergence is a meeting place, a site where things come together.

Though digital convergence is often used to indicate the last of these definitions, the other mean-

tous and invisible computing, through small, relatively inexpensive devices that merge multiple media and communications technologies, will reshape the way individuals and organisations collaborate and share information.

Convergence in this sense of the term includes *content and application development* for film, video games, music, advertising, and mass media; *distribution*, including wireless, broadband, VoIP and more; *hardware*, such as cell phones, mobile devices, game consoles, and so on.

This digital convergence is often talked of in technological terms (such as my cell phone, digital camera or my gaming console). This emphasis on the technical is not surprising because there is still a lot of intricate and difficult work (regarding communication standards, interoperability, hardware handshakes and software bugs) that need to be configured and deciphered.